

SEA OF UNCERTAINTY

Rules of Play

BOOK I - CORE RULES

Development Manuscript v0.6

Operational naval warfare under conditions of incomplete information

Source baseline: public Sea of Uncertainty repository, current Prototype Rules v0.5, Design Constitution v0.3, and Design Notes.

This manuscript reorganizes source-supported rules into professional regulatory prose. Proposed or unresolved material is explicitly marked.

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1.0 INTRODUCTION AND RULES CONVENTIONS

Sea of Uncertainty is an operational-level naval wargame in which players command Formations conducting maneuver, reconnaissance, screening, support, strike, recovery, and replenishment operations under incomplete information and asynchronous timing.

The game does not use conventional alternating player turns. Each Formation has its own Ready Time. The interaction of Ready Time, Contact information, Command Attention, Reaction, Endurance, and Entropy determines operational tempo.

1.1 The Core Play Loop

The governing sequence is: Ready - Choose - Act - React - Resolve - Entropy - Schedule. A player normally makes the important choice before any die roll associated with that choice.

1.2 Rules Precedence

Where two rules conflict, apply the more specific rule. For this development manuscript, the intended order is Scenario Special Rule, card text, Formation-specific rule, then general rule.

MANUSCRIPT STATUS: Rules already supported by the current repository are written as ordinary rules. Where the source remains ambiguous, the rule is marked DESIGN HOLD. Advanced material appears in Book II and is optional/provisional until adopted.

1.3 Hidden Information

Contacts are a player's information picture, not literal enemy pieces. Players may not inspect hidden enemy positions, unrevealed identities, or concealed information except when a rule requires revelation.

2.0 SCALE

2.1 Map Scale

The current operational baseline is exactly 20 nautical miles between hex centers. This value is an approved playtest baseline rather than a final simulation claim.

2.2 Time Scale

One Ready-Time interval represents approximately two hours. An Action costing 2 Time therefore occupies a Formation for approximately four hours at the current scale.

2.3 Formation Scale

Counters generally represent operational Formations rather than individual ships. Typical Formation categories are carrier groups, surface action groups, submarines, air groups, amphibious forces, and logistics forces.

3.0 COMPONENTS

Component	Function
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Operational Map	Hex map showing sea, littoral, land, objectives, and scenario features.
Formation Counters	Operational maneuver elements.
Formation Cards	Ratings, weapons, Endurance, Mission, and status.
Ready Markers	Next Time at which a Formation may act.
Contact Markers	Location, Identity, and Age of enemy information.
Command Slots	Finite headquarters attention.
Entropy Markers and Cards	Friction, Disruption, Destruction and their manifestations.
Command Response Cards	Player-held command interventions.
Weapon Expenditure Markers	Abstract major offensive expenditure.

4.0 FORMATION RATINGS

Rating	Meaning
Move	Mobility.
Search	Detection capability.
Signature	Detectability.
Strike	Offensive strength.
Defense	Survivability and defensive power.
ASW	Anti-submarine capability.
Command	Initiative and autonomy.
Endurance	Operational staying power.

DESIGN HOLD: The current source names Move and ASW ratings but does not yet define complete universal procedures for how Move modifies the 1/2/3-hex movement modes or how ASW differs from ordinary Search/Combat. Book II presents optional advanced treatments.

5.0 OPERATIONAL TIME

5.1 Ready Time

Every Formation has a Ready marker. A Formation normally performs one Operational Action when the Operational Clock reaches its Ready Time.

5.2 No Player Turns

There are no conventional Player Turns or Game Turns. The game proceeds from one Ready Formation to the next.

5.3 Advance the Clock

If no Formation is Ready at the current Time, advance directly to the lowest occupied Ready Time. Empty Time intervals are not processed unless Contact aging, delayed information, scenario timing, or another rule requires them.

5.4 Scheduling a Formation

After resolving an Action, determine the Formation's new Ready Time as Current Time + Base Action Time + applicable delays and terrain/card effects - any legal Push Through reduction. Place its Ready marker accordingly.

6.0 SAME-TIME PRIORITY

6.1 Current Repository Conflict

The current source contains two same-Time procedures: an earlier lower-Entropy/higher-Command/d6 sequence and a later Sequence-of-Play rule that first gives priority to the side that did not act most recently.

6.2 Development Baseline

For this manuscript, the later Sequence-of-Play language is treated as the working baseline: if both sides have Formations tied at the earliest Ready Time, priority passes to the side that did not act most recently. Within that side, use lower Entropy, then higher Command, then stable Formation order. Alternate eligible sides while both have Ready Formations at that Time.

DESIGN HOLD: Section 6.2 is a reconciliation of conflicting source text and should be formally ratified before a final print edition.

7.0 STANDING MISSIONS

7.1 Mission Elements

Every Formation maintains a standing Mission consisting of Task, Objective, Posture, and Trigger.

7.2 Continuing the Mission

A Formation may continue its current Mission without occupying Command Attention. The player is not required to issue a new order simply because a Formation became Ready.

7.3 Immediate Retasking

Changing a Formation's Mission immediately normally uses one Command Slot. The Mission change represents active headquarters intervention rather than routine execution.

7.4 Mission Triggers

A Trigger is a preauthorized condition under which a Formation may alter behavior without waiting for a fresh order. A typical Trigger might authorize interception of a hostile Contact entering a specified protection area.

8.0 OPERATIONAL ACTIONS

Action	Base Time	Principal Choice
Move	2	Cautious / Normal / High Tempo
Search	2	Passive / Active / Focused
Strike	2	Target / Salvo / Immediate or Synchronized
Patrol / Screen	1	Defensive / Balanced / Aggressive
Support	1-2	Which friendly action to improve
Recover	2	Which eligible Entropy effect to address
Replenish	3	Which capability to restore
Hold	1	Preserve position / reduce exposure

8.1 Action Declaration

When a Formation becomes Ready, declare one legal Action and all choices required before resolution: target, posture, salvo, Support commitment, Command Slot use, and any Response Card whose timing is before resolution.

8.2 One Action

Unless a rule specifically grants a Reaction, Response, or additional effect, a Ready Formation conducts one Operational Action before receiving a new Ready Time.

9.0 MOVEMENT

Mode	Distance	Benefit	Cost
Cautious	1 hex	-1 Signature	Slowest repositioning
Normal	2 hexes	No modifier	No special protection

High Tempo	3 hexes	Fastest repositioning	+1 Signature; Friction event
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9.1 Movement Procedure

Choose the Movement Mode before moving. Move from hex to adjacent hex up to the selected allowance. A Formation may stop before using its full allowance.

9.2 High-Tempo Friction

A High-Tempo Move causes a Friction event. Mark Friction if not already marked and draw a Friction Effect Card under 22.0. Repeated Friction events may create additional Friction cards even though the source itself is already marked.

9.3 Patrol Interaction

Entering an enemy Patrol or Screen protection area may create a Reaction Opportunity under 12.0 and 16.0.

DESIGN HOLD: The source states that Land blocks non-air destinations and Littoral adds one Ready-Time in the digital baseline, but does not state whether the Littoral cost is per hex, per Action, or for ending movement there.

10.0 SEARCH

10.1 Purpose

Search attempts to establish a new Contact or improve the Location or Identity of an existing Contact. A legal Search costs its full Time even when it finds nothing.

Mode	Modifier	Exposure	Command
Passive	+0	No additional Signature effect	None
Active	+1	Formation becomes Loud	None
Focused	+2	Normal exposure	1 Command Slot

10.2 Search Center

Select any legal hex within the Search Mode's permitted range, or select an existing Contact and use its last-known hex as the Search center.

10.3 Search Footprint

The Search Footprint consists of the selected hex and all six adjacent hexes. Resolve one Search Test for each hidden enemy Formation actually occupying the footprint.

10.4 Search Formula

Search Value = Search Rating + Search Mode + Target Signature - actual target Range + Support. Hidden target modifiers and exact positions are resolved privately.

Actual Range	Penalty
Same hex	0
1 hex	-1
2 hexes	-2
3+ hexes	Sensor/scenario dependent

Final Search Value	Success on 1d6
0 or less	5-6
1-2	3-6
3-4	2-6
5+	Automatic

10.5 Successful Search

On a successful Search, choose one result applicable to the target: create a new Low-Location/Unknown-Identity Contact, improve Location by one level, or improve Identity by one level. Set a successfully refreshed Contact's Age to 0.

10.6 Search Ranges

The current digital baseline uses Search reaches of 8, 10, and 12 hexes for Passive, Active, and Focused Search. These are playtest baselines and may later vary by Formation or sensor type.

11.0 CONTACTS

Attribute	States
Location	Low / Medium / High
Identity	Unknown / General / Identified
Age	0 Current / 1 Usable / 2 Stale / 3+ Very Stale

11.1 Nature of Contacts

A Contact represents the observing side's information, not an enemy unit. A Contact may be stale, false, misidentified, or displaced from the target's present location.

11.2 Aging

Increase the Age of an unrefreshed Contact when the applicable Time interval advances. At Age 3+, degrade Location by one level for each further Time interval.

11.3 Lost Contact

A Low-Location Contact at Age 3+ becomes Lost and is removed.

11.4 False Contacts

False Contacts use the same Location, Identity, and Age conventions as real Contacts until disproven or aged out.

12.0 PATROL AND SCREEN

Posture	Effect	Tradeoff
Defensive	+1 Defense when reacting	No interception bonus
Balanced	No modifier	Maximum flexibility
Aggressive	+1 interception-related Reaction	+1 Signature

12.1 Declaring Patrol or Screen

A Formation spends 1 Time to enter a Patrol or Screen posture. When Screening, identify the friendly Formation or objective being protected.

12.2 Protection

A Screen may react first to eligible threats entering its protection area. The present digital Reaction/interception baseline begins at one hex.

DESIGN HOLD: The printed game still requires a single authoritative definition of Screen/Patrol protection radius and whether it varies by Formation type.

13.0 SUPPORT

13.1 General

Support sacrifices a Formation's independent Action to improve another friendly operation. Common current effects are +1 Strike, +1 Search, +1 Defense, +1 ASW Search, or +1 Synchronization.

13.2 Declaration

The supporting Formation must be eligible to Support and must declare the supported action before that action resolves. It receives its own Ready Time based on the Support Action cost.

DESIGN HOLD: The current source does not yet define universal Support range, stacking, duration, or limits on multiple supporting Formations. These are developed as optional rules in Book II.

14.0 STRIKE OPERATIONS

14.1 Strike Procedure

A Strike consists of four decisions: choose a Contact in range; choose Salvo commitment; choose immediate or synchronized timing; then allow any eligible defender Reaction before resolving Combat.

Salvo	Attack Modifier	Cost
Light	+0	Low/minimal expenditure
Standard	+1	Normal expenditure
Heavy	+2	Mark Weapon Expenditure

14.2 Weapon Range

Strike range varies by Formation and Salvo in the current digital baseline. A universal range table is not yet part of the source rules.

15.0 TARGETING

Contact Condition	Modifier
Low Location	-2
Medium Location	-1
High Location	0
Identified	+1
Age 2+	Optional -1 by scenario scale

15.1 Applying Targeting

Apply the Location modifier and any applicable Identity modifier when calculating Attack. Contact Age may also impose the scenario-defined penalty.

DESIGN HOLD: The Age 2+ targeting penalty remains explicitly optional in the source. Book II provides an advanced aging schedule, but the final core rule has not been ratified.

16.0 REACTION

Reaction	Benefit	Cost/Consequence
Defend	+1 Defense	No offensive benefit
Evade	+1 Defense; move 1 hex after combat	May abandon geometry/objective
Counterattack	Light Strike afterward if still capable	No Defense bonus
Hold	Preserve position	No modifier

16.1 Reaction Limit

A Formation normally reacts once between its own Actions. A Reaction does not change its Ready Time unless a specific rule or card says otherwise.

16.2 Entropy Restrictions

A Disrupted Formation may not Counterattack. A Disorganized Formation may only Defend or Evade unless Command Attention is spent to force another legal Reaction.

17.0 COMBAT

17.1 Attack Value

Attack = Strike + Salvo + Targeting + Support + Synchronization - applicable Entropy effects.

17.2 Defense Value

Defense = Defense rating + Reaction + Screen/Support - applicable Entropy effects.

Attack - Defense	Combat Band
-2 or worse	Poor
-1 to +1	Even
+2 to +3	Favorable
+4 or more	Dominant

Band	1	2-5	6
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Poor	No Effect	No Effect	Light
Even	No Effect	Light	Heavy
Favorable	Light	Heavy	Crippled
Dominant	Heavy	Crippled	Destroyed

17.3 Bounded Randomness

The attacker and defender establish the Combat Band through choices and circumstances before the die is rolled. The 1d6 result determines the exact effect within that band.

18.0 DAMAGE

Result	Core Effect
Light	Temporary impairment; exact universal effect is not yet finalized.
Heavy	Mark Destruction; -1 offensive capability; draw Destruction Effect Card.
Crippled	Mark Destruction; reduced movement; no Heavy Salvo; Reaction limited.
Destroyed	Remove Formation or render it permanently combat ineffective.

DESIGN HOLD: Light Damage, exact Crippled movement reduction, and exact Crippled Reaction restrictions remain underdefined in the source. Book II offers an Advanced Damage system intended to carry this detail.

19.0 SYNCHRONIZED STRIKES

1. Assign 1 Command Slot.
2. Declare participating Formations and intended Strike Time.
3. All participants must be Ready by that Time.
4. Resolve all participating attacks before the defender fully recovers.

Attack in Sequence	Defender Modifier
First	No penalty

Second	-1 Defense
Third and later	-2 Defense

19.1 Coordination Friction

Three or more independent participating Formations suffer a Friction event.

19.2 Lost Target

If target information becomes Lost before execution, abort, proceed using whatever stale targeting remains legal, or retask using Command Attention.

20.0 ENTROPY

Source	Typical Trigger	Universal Effect
Friction	High Tempo, synchronization, extended operations, rapid retask	+1 Time after complex Actions
Disruption	EW, cyber, deception, command failure	-1 Search and Synchronization
Destruction	Heavy or worse damage	-1 offensive capability

20.1 Entropy as Unavailable Capability

Entropy does not represent morale or additional physical damage. It represents the portion of a Formation's remaining physical potential that cannot presently be employed effectively because of operational disorder.

DESIGN HOLD: The source uses the term complex Action but does not define it. Book II proposes a formal Advanced Complex Action rule.

21.0 ENTROPY LEVEL AND COHESION

Different Sources Marked	Entropy	Cohesion
0	Low	Cohesive
1	Moderate	Cohesive
2	High	Disrupted
3	Critical	Disorganized

21.1 Repeated Same-Source Events

Additional events from an already-marked source do not increase the number of different sources for Entropy Level, but they may add additional Effect Cards and therefore additional specific penalties.

22.0 ENTROPY EFFECT CARDS

22.1 Drawing a Card

Every Entropy event draws one physical Effect Card from the matching Friction, Disruption, or Destruction deck. Attach the card to the affected Formation and apply its printed effect in addition to the universal source effect.

22.2 Stacking

Repeated events from the same source draw additional cards. Their printed effects stack unless a card says otherwise.

22.3 Current Deck Size

The current component set contains 12 Friction cards, 12 Disruption cards, and 12 Destruction cards, for 36 Entropy Effect Cards total.

22.4 Deck Exhaustion

When a draw pile is exhausted, recycle and shuffle the corresponding discard pile.

22.5 Card Responses

If an attached Entropy card prints a specific Response, use that Response when its conditions are met.

23.0 RECOVERY

23.1 Recover Action

Recover costs 2 Time. Select and discard one eligible Friction or Disruption Effect Card.

23.2 Source Marker

After discarding a card, remove the corresponding source marker only if no other Effect Card of that source remains attached.

23.3 Destruction

Normal Recovery does not remove Destruction. Destruction cards remain until repaired, reorganized, replenished, or removed by another specific capability.

MANUSCRIPT RECONCILIATION: This case reconciles the newer Entropy-card rule with the older shorthand Recover rule. It should be formally approved before final publication.

24.0 COMMAND ATTENTION

24.1 Command Slots

The current baseline is 3 Command Slots per side. A Slot represents active headquarters attention rather than spendable currency.

24.2 Uses

Command Slots are presently used for Focused Search, immediate retasking, Synchronized Strike planning, Push Through, Restore Command, or forcing a Disorganized Formation into a complex Action.

DESIGN HOLD: A universal release timing for every Command Slot assignment is not yet defined in the source. Book II provides a proposed Advanced Command Slot timing model.

25.0 COMMAND RESPONSE CARDS

25.1 Initial Hand

Each player begins with 3 Response Cards.

25.2 Playing a Response

When its condition applies, reveal the card, resolve its benefit, then pay any printed Cost. Unless a card says otherwise, discard it after resolution.

25.3 Current Deck

The current card set contains 24 distinct Response Cards, C-01 through C-24.

DESIGN HOLD: The source says players draw or gain further Responses through play and Recovery, but does not yet define one universal draw schedule or hand limit.

26.0 PUSH THROUGH

26.1 Procedure

If Friction would add +1 Time to an Action, assign one free Command Slot to ignore that delay. Then mark one Command Strain.

26.2 Command Strain

At 2 Command Strain, lose one Command Slot until HQ Recovery.

DESIGN HOLD: HQ Recovery is referenced by the source but not yet procedurally defined. An Advanced rule is provided in Book II.

27.0 HOLD

27.1 Procedure

Hold costs 1 Time. The Formation remains in place, may reduce Signature to Quiet if circumstances permit, and preserves Endurance.

27.2 Operational Uses

Hold may be used to maintain an ambush, wait for intelligence, preserve a Screen, conserve Endurance, or wait for synchronized partners.

28.0 ENDURANCE

State	Effect
Ready	No penalty.
Extended	High Tempo marks Friction; Recover may take +1 Time.
Critical	Move -1 hex; no Heavy Salvo; complex Actions mark Friction.

28.1 Current Degradation Baseline

The present prototype degrades Endurance one step after three major Actions without Replenishment.

DESIGN HOLD: Major Action is not formally defined, and the Design Notes identify action-count degradation as provisional. Book II offers an Advanced Endurance treatment.

29.0 REPLENISHMENT

29.1 Replenish Action

Replenishment costs 3 Time and requires Logistics Access. It may restore Endurance, Weapon Expenditure, or repairable capability.

29.2 Vulnerability

A Formation undergoing Replenishment may normally only Defend if attacked.

DESIGN HOLD: Logistics Access and the exact repairable capabilities are not yet defined in the source. Advanced Logistics and Repair rules appear in Book II.

30.0 DECEPTION

30.1 Eligibility

A scenario-capable Formation may use Support to create or reinforce a False Contact.

30.2 Operational Effect

Deception is successful when the enemy physically reallocates movement, Search, Command Attention, Support, or weapons in response to false information.

31.0 COMMAND DISRUPTION

Effect	Consequence
Degraded HQ	Temporarily lose 1 Command Slot.
Delayed Information	A Contact update arrives 1 Time later.
Broken Link	A Formation cannot receive a new Mission until restored.

31.1 Standing Mission

A Broken Link does not erase the Formation's existing Mission. It continues under its standing Mission and Trigger until command is restored or another rule intervenes.

32.0 VICTORY

32.1 Operational Objectives

Scenarios should primarily reward operational results such as escort, denial, control, preservation, successful transit, withdrawal, or maintaining combat capability in required areas.

32.2 Destruction as a Means

Destroyed enemy Formations matter because they alter operational objectives. The system is not intended to reduce victory to simple hull-counting unless a scenario explicitly does so.

33.0 SEQUENCE OF PLAY

1. Advance Time to the earliest Ready Formation(s).
2. Update Information: age unrefreshed Contacts and resolve delayed information.
3. Select a Ready Formation, using same-Time priority when required.
4. Choose one Operational Action.
5. Choose all required posture, commitment, target, Support, and Command decisions.
6. Enemy Reacts when eligible.

7. Resolve Search, Combat, or the selected Action.
8. Apply consequences: Contacts, Damage, Signature, Endurance, Weapon Expenditure, Entropy cards and markers.
9. Check Entropy Level and Cohesion.
10. Schedule the Formation's next Action and return to Step 1.

34.0 CORE EXAMPLES AND RULES HOLDS

34.1 Worked Search Example

Blue CSG-71 is Ready at Time 06 with a Medium-Location, General-Identity Contact two hexes west at Age 1. Blue chooses Focused Search instead of Strike. Search 3 + Focused 2 + target Signature 1 - range 2 = 4, requiring 2-6. Blue rolls 4 and improves Location to High. The Contact becomes High/General/Age 0. Search costs 2 Time, so CSG-71 becomes Ready at Time 08; a Red Formation Ready at 07 may act first. Blue traded tempo for better information.

34.2 Open Core Holds

- Move rating integration.
- ASW procedure.
- Support range/stacking/duration.
- Patrol/Screen radius.
- Age-2 targeting penalty.
- Light Damage and exact Crippled effects.
- Definition of complex Action.
- Command Slot release timing.
- Response draw schedule/hand limit.
- HQ Recovery.
- Logistics Access, repair, and reorganization.
- Endurance degradation trigger.

NEXT STEP: Resolve only the holds that matter during playtest. Do not expand the core merely because an Advanced Rule exists.